

The Concept of Our Great Power

Codex Reference: VI,4

Translated by: Francis E. Williams, Frederik Wisse, and Douglas M. Parrott

Source: Robinson, J.M. (ed.), *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd rev. ed. (HarperSanFrancisco, 1990), p. 311ff.

Editor's Introduction

Introduced by Francis E. Williams

Translated by Frederik Wisse

Edited by Douglas M. Parrott

The Concept of Our Great Power is a Christian Gnostic "salvation history." Beginning with creation, it recounts the workings of God's justice and mercy in the conflict between good and evil, ending with the final beatitude. Unusually for a gnostic work the tractate is "apocalyptic," that is, its climax is a dramatic description of the end of the world. Even here, however, it betrays its gnostic character; in gnostic fashion it expects no general resurrection, and contemplates the salvation of nothing material.

"Our great power" is the document's supreme God. He is transcendent and "above all powers" - including the Old Testament God, the "Father of the flesh." However, he intervenes in history; it is he who builds the ark and rescues Noah from the flood.

The very first lines of the tractate make it clear that human salvation depends upon knowing our great power. As the title has probably been taken from the first line, it might well be rendered "the perception of our great power," or even "the knowledge of our great power."

In the manner typical of apocalyptic, the tractate divides all history into three "aeons." The first, the "aeon of the flesh," ends with the flood. In the second, or "psychic" aeon, the revealer appears. He is clearly meant to be the New Testament Christ, though the author avoids that title and is careful not to say explicitly that the revealer is crucified.

The second aeon ends with a war among wicked angelic rulers - the "Archons" - the appearance of an antichristlike figure, and the destruction of the world by fire. Though the fire consumes matter, it purifies souls; together with "the saints," the purified souls then live forever in the great power's "indestructible aeon."

While the tractate's message is clear in broad outline, its details are often puzzling. Some figures well known from other gnostic theology - "the Mother," for example - are mentioned but seem to play no part in the story. Incidents sometimes repeat themselves, or come at unexpected places in the narrative - thus the fire can be understood to destroy the universe twice. The transitions between episodes are often abrupt; so, likewise, are the changes in the person of pronouns and the person and tense of verbs. Of a few passages it is even difficult to make connected sense.

Some of the problems can be solved simply by an attentive reading of the tractate, and a recent interpretation has presented the work as a self-consistent whole. Other investigators, however, may still feel that the document has undergone more than one redaction, or at least been extensively glossed. In particular, the question whether an original Jewish apocalypse underlies certain portions of the work seems worthy of investigation.

Even the language of the tractate, a mixture of Sahidic and Subakhmimic dialects of Coptic, calls for explanation. It may simply be that a Sahidic-speaking scribe attempted to translate a Subakhmimic writing into his own dialect. Some, however, explain the language as “proto-Sahidic,” a stage of Coptic earlier than that of the Sahidic New Testament.

Questions of the tractate’s date and provenance are bound up with those of its language and presumed literary history. If the language is felt to be proto-Sahidic, the document will be dated rather early. There is, however, an apparent reference to the Anhomoean heresy; one who sees this as stemming from the original author, rather than a glossator, will wish to place the document in the fourth century C.E.

Similar uncertainties make it difficult to determine the document’s provenance. If the statement that the Word “appeared in the east at the first” is the author’s, the tractate might come from Asia Minor. If the words in question are a gloss, there is less reason to hold this view.